Two strategies worth keeping

Everything below is a measured result rather than a plan. One is a bot validated over five years of backtests; the other is your own discretionary trading, measured over six weeks of real fills. Sample sizes are printed beside every figure, because in six months you will need to know which of these numbers were solid and which were provisional.

+0.204R	+0.403R	434 / 18
NAS100 BOT, PER TRADE	US500 BY HAND, PER TRADE	TRADES BEHIND EACH

The discretionary trading is running at roughly twice the bot's edge. It is also measured on 18 trades against 434, so expect it to come down.

1 · NAS100 opening-range bot

A wide overnight range, a short late window, a plain stop and target. No breakeven, no trailing, no risk reduction — every attempt to add those made it worse. Profitable in all five full years tested on one unchanged configuration.

The configuration

Setting	Value
Instrument	US100.cash (NAS100)
Range window	02:00 – 09:30 New York
Entry window	10:00 – 11:00 New York
Range time zone	America/New_York
Trading time zone	America/New_York
Stop	60 points, fixed
Target	4R (rarely reached; most exits are on the clock)
Volume filter	1.2x the trailing 20-bar average
Direction	Long and short
Breakeven / trailing / risk reduction	All OFF
Max trades per day	1

Five-year record

Year	Trades	Net	Per trade	PF	Minus top 5
2022	105	+$2,914	+$27.75	1.44	+$922
2023	106	+$1,671	+$15.77	1.29	-$234
2024 (tuned)	85	+$2,352	+$27.67	1.52	+$359
2025	88	+$1,368	+$15.55	1.25	-$622
2026 (to Aug)	50	+$553	+$11.07	1.16	-$1,434
Total	**434**	**+$8,859**	**+$20.41**	**1.34**	**+$6,859**

Why this one is trusted. Removing the ten best trades from 434 still leaves +$4,867. The equivalent test on the US30 version turned five years negative by removing a single trade. Worst drawdown was -$1,109, about 11R, and

70% of months finished positive. Only 2024 is fitted — the 60pt stop was chosen there. The other four years ran afterwards on that same setting and all four are positive.

What was tested and rejected

Change	Result	Verdict
Stop = 50% of the day's range	+$3,567 vs +$8,859	rejected
Risk reduction, 1R / 50%	3 of 5 years positive	rejected
Risk reduction, 0.75R / 75%	+$1,281 over six years	unproven

The 50% stop failed for a reason worth remembering: it raised the win rate from 38.5% to 47.2%, exactly as intended, but the average win fell from $209 to $111. Risk is fixed in dollars, so a wider stop buys a smaller position and the same move earns less. Fewer losses did not pay for smaller wins.

The 0.75R / 75% variant is the one open question. It showed a proper dose-response — 25% of risk left on gave -$263, 50% gave -$25, 75% gave +$437, and no intervention is zero by definition, so there is a peak rather than a slide. That is what a real effect looks like. It is still only +$2.53 a trade against a base of +$20.41, and it goes to demo beside the baseline rather than into production.

Sizing it for a prop account

Risk per trade	Return / yr	Worst drawdown	Survives a 10% limit?
0.50%	9.6%	5.5%	yes
0.75%	14.4%	8.3%	yes
1.00%	19.3%	11.1%	NO
1.50%	28.9%	16.6%	NO

Size differently for the challenge and the funded account. A failed challenge costs a fee; a failed funded account costs the account and months of work. Higher risk gets you funded faster even after retries — 1.5% takes about 3 months against 12 at 0.5% — but the historical drawdown at 1% would breach a 10% limit. Pass at 1–1.5%, then drop to 0.5–0.75% once funded.

2 · US500 discretionary, afternoons

Your own trading, measured over six weeks of live fills at a fixed $300 risk. It is the strongest thing in this document, and the smallest sample.

	Trades	Net	Profit factor
US500	18	+$2,238.94	2.04
Everything else	32	-$4,426.00	—
The account	**50**	**-$2,187.06**	**0.77**

US500 made **+$124.39 a trade**; everything else lost **-$138.31**. A permutation test over the 50 trades puts that difference at **p = 0.035** — real, not noise. Trading US500 alone over those six weeks would have turned -$2,187 into +$2,239.

In R terms, at $300 = 1R

Measure	Value
Trades	15
Win rate	60%
Average win	+1.43R
Average loss	-1.13R

Expectancy	+0.403R per trade
Strongest cut	ORB US500 short: 6 trades, +$1,754, 83% win

The rules that follow from this. Trade US500 in the afternoon only. Keep risk fixed — the journal shows a median loss of $318 against a $300 target, which is exactly what controlled risk looks like. No news trades: the one in the record lost $1,531 on a $600 intended risk, 2.6x, because a stop does not hold when it is most needed. No UK100, EU50, GER40 or JP225 until something changes.

Why the other instruments were dropped

Instrument	Trades	Net	Win rate
UK100	15	-$2,163	27%
JP225	9	-$759	22%
EU50	3	-$719	33%
GER40	1	-$444	0%
US100 (news)	3	-$336	67%

UK100 was checked for a profitable subset and has none: long loses, short loses, ORB loses, inverse ORB loses, and the median trade is -$315. The worst week of the six was the week six instruments were traded; the best was five trades across three.

The escalation episode. Risk was raised from $300 to $450 at around $102,500 on the challenge. During that window US500 made +$1,146 at the larger size while everything else lost $3,406. The sizing decision cost an extra $1,072; the instrument selection cost three times that. The lesson is not that raising risk was wrong — it is that raising risk magnifies whatever you are actually doing, and four of the five things being done had no edge.

3 · The method that found all this

Twenty-plus bots were built before this, and all of them looked profitable in backtest. The difference was not better strategies — it was these rules.

Reserve a year and spend it once

Choose settings on some years, then test on a year you have never looked at. The moment you adjust anything after seeing that year, it is spent and can never be evidence again. The measured cost of ignoring this on US30 was +$55.60 a trade in-sample against -$23.21 out — a swing of $78.81 that existed only on paper.

Judge on the median trade, not the total

A total can be one lucky trade. The median tells you what a typical trade does. US30 had a median of -$105 in every year it was tested, which was the tell long before the totals admitted it.

Strip out the best five trades

If a five-year result turns negative when its top five trades are removed, the edge lives in a tail you cannot rely on. US30 turned negative on removing one trade from 432. NAS100 survives losing ten from 434.

Change one thing at a time, across every year

A change that helps in one year and hurts in two is noise wearing a disguise. Decide the pass criteria before running it, and write them down — otherwise the criteria move to fit the result.

Count how many variants you tried

The best of five attempts looks good whether or not anything is real. If a winner has no coherent pattern around it — neighbouring settings performing like neighbours — it is probably selection rather than an effect.

What comes next. Run the NAS100 bot on two demo accounts, baseline against the 0.75R / 75% variant, and let live fills settle the open question. Keep trading US500 in the afternoons at fixed risk. Re-check the US500 edge after another 50 trades — not to optimise it, only to confirm it holds on a larger sample. Leave the mornings empty until something earns the slot.

Every figure here is a backtest or a six-week journal. Neither is a promise. The point of the method in section 3 is that when something stops working, you will find out from the data rather than from the account balance.